



Two stars, and counting

After **another final win** over Delhi Capitals, RCB's women have made trophies routine and ambition louder.

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Until the Women's Premier League became a reality in 2023, Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) was a franchise that had grown accustomed to ridicule for its myriad missteps. In a decade-and-a-half of existence in the Indian Premier League till then, the troughs had far outweighed the peaks; it had made all of three finals in 15 seasons.

With the passing of every edition, the catchphrase '*Ee Sala Cup Namde (this year, the cup will be ours)*' seemed like a rallying cry that

belonged firmly in the realm of fantasy.

But then the WPL came along, and all it took was the second edition of the women's competition in 2024 for Smriti Mandhana and Co. to turn that slogan into '*Ee Sala Cup Namdu (this year, the cup is ours)*'. **The Bengaluru outfit strolled to the title after thumping Delhi Capitals in the final, enabling its fervent fans to revel in glory at long last.**

Just a couple of years have passed since, but the franchise's lean phase now seems to well and truly be a thing of the past. Having broken the long-standing drought in the IPL as well last year, although subsequent events during celebrations back in

Bengaluru marred the moment to a great extent, the southern club's latest high came at the Kotambi Stadium in Vadodara on the night of February 5, when Smriti's team lifted the WPL trophy for the second time. DC was the runner-up once again.

RCB's champagne-popping exploits were largely built on a collective effort, but Smriti was a cut above the rest on the big night. The 29-year-old opening batter is among the finest practitioners in her field right now, and she was not going to let go of the opportunity to reinforce her pre-eminence with a title on the line.

When she strode out for the chase, she was staring at a daunting